

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 1/12: Central thesis

Harappan architecture is best read as civic urbanism grounded in excavated form.
Start with what is built; infer only what the evidence can bear.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 2/12: Two timelines

ARCHAEOLOGICAL -> Early Harappan foundations -> Mature Urban Harappan peak -> Late/Post-Urban change.

MODERN RECOVERY -> 1853 Cunningham seal notice -> 1921 Harappa excavation -> 1922 Mohenjo-daro excavation -> 1931 Marshall

Dholavira heritage rail -> 1968 discovery -> 1989-2005 excavation seasons -> 2021 UNESCO inscription -> 2025 direct UPSC

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 3/12: Topic ownership and building classes

Topic 1 owns built form, civic planning, evidence limits and answer route.

Building classes -> dwelling houses / public buildings / public baths.

Keep full political chronology and decline theories outside the core architectural answer.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 4/12: Grid and zoning

Right-angled roads running north-south and east-west -> pre-planning.

Citadel -> raised western public zone.

Lower town -> larger residential spread.

Safe inference -> functional zoning, not rigid caste map.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 5/12: Material and houses

Standardised baked-brick proportions and repeated brick courses -> shared technical norm.

Private wells + designated bathing areas + some stairways -> planning reaches ordinary houses.

Rule -> keep technical mortar / waterproofing detail specific, not universal.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 6/12: Drainage network

House drain -> covered street drain -> access / cleaning point -> cesspit.

Meaning -> linked and maintainable civic engineering, not isolated drains.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 7/12: Public structures and label caution

Great Bath -> secure public water structure at Mohenjo-daro.

Ritual cleansing -> plausible inference.

Raised platforms and ventilation -> support storage reading; "granary" remains conventional.

No confirmed palace or temple -> strongest negative finding.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 8/12: Regional adaptation

Mohenjo-daro -> Great Bath + drains.

Harappa -> large platforms and granary-complex tradition.

Dholavira -> fortifications + reservoirs + all three phases.

Lothal -> basin conventionally called dockyard, function debated.

Kalibangan -> distinct planning.

Verdict -> standardisation through adaptation.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 9/12: Evidence ladder

STRONG -> grid, bricks, wells, drains, baths, reservoirs, excavated plans.

MODERATE -> storage, labour coordination, differentiation.

WEAK / DISPUTED -> exact polity, exact ritual office, exact dockyard function.

UNSUPPORTED -> named king, confirmed temple, confirmed palace, fixed caste map, certain proto-Shiva identity.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 10/12: Comparison

Harappan visible surplus -> streets, drains, baths, wells, storage, reservoirs.

Egypt / Mesopotamia -> securely attested royal-sacred monumentality.

Safe verdict -> different visible priority, not absence of authority or belief.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 11/12: Continuity and water firewall

Harappan civic water works != later stepwell / temple tank / bauli traditions.

Rani-ki-Vav, Modhera Surya Kund, Hoysala kalyani, Potramarai Kulam, Mandu baulis and Sudarshana lake belong to later cont

Shared concern with water does not prove one uninterrupted architectural lineage.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 12/12: 2025 answer route

Open -> grid and pre-planning.

Move -> citadel / lower town + public structure.

Add -> drainage as standout engineering feature.

Add -> standardised baked-brick construction + domestic wells / bathing spaces.

Close -> Dholavira and the caveat that no palace or temple is securely identified.